

Chapter 140_2 - Extinguishing Fire

Ning Fuyi hadn't returned to Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate for decades. Now, revisiting this familiar place, her heart was filled with countless thoughts.

Everything at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate was as usual, except for many unfamiliar faces. Elder Pingyao and Elder Jingshan led a group of disciples standing below the mountain gate, welcoming the arrival of various immortal sects.

When Ning Fuyi's group descended, she witnessed firsthand the discomfort in everyone's eyes. This discomfort didn't come from anything else, but from her and Chu Qingqiu's tightly clasped hands.

Normally, she wouldn't like to be so conspicuous. Although the jianghu¹ rumors had already spread colorful stories about the two of them, they would still need to conceal it when face to face.

But now with human calamity right before them, Ning Fuyi wouldn't miss any opportunity to still be together with Chu Qingqiu.

Two figures, one black and one white, leaped down from mid-air. The disciples' eyes couldn't keep up, sometimes staring at their expressions, sometimes staring at their interlocked fingers, busy beyond measure.

"The rumors really aren't made up?" A bald male disciple with a shiny forehead covered his face in shock. "Yesterday I was still saying these rumors were ridiculous and couldn't possibly be true."

"I already told you, but you didn't believe me yourself. Don't blame me," said female disciple Tao Tao with sky-high braids, swaying her braids proudly.

"But I still find it incredible. They're separated by a thousand years! When the Divine Venerable became the Divine Venerable, that Ning Fuyi was probably still waiting to reincarnate in some corner of the underworld!" the bald male disciple said with a bitter smile.

"Yes, senior brother, I think the same way!" Xiang Yushan said, lying on his shoulder.

A sword extended from the side, pushing everyone aside. Feng Ge said coldly: "What are you chattering about? You can't even keep your backs straight—are you waiting for other sects to laugh at us?"

Ning Fuyi heard the buzzing voices and knew what they were whispering about, but she didn't interfere much. She only gripped Chu Qingqiu's hand tighter, and when ascending the steps, she even lifted their hands slightly. It seemed like assistance, but actually it was to make their sleeves spread apart, making their hand-holding even more conspicuous.

Chu Qingqiu secretly pinched her and whispered: "Childish."

"What, you don't want them to see?" Ning Fuyi said.

"If you say another word, I'll throw you down the mountain," Chu Qingqiu's lips barely moved.

Jiuying followed behind them with her arms crossed, rolling her eyes at the two, her mouth almost twisting to the back of her head.

When the two ascended the mountain gate, Elder Pingyao's eyes didn't escape the impact of those hands either. However, she was battle-tested after all. After looking for a while, she pulled Elder Jingshan to bow their heads in salute: "Sect Leader."

"Tianji Sword Sect, Ghost Sight Sect, Blissful Union Sect, and Void Brightness Sect are already waiting in Cloud Deep Hall. Please, Sect Leader, move to Cloud Deep Hall," she said.

"Did Flying Flower Sect not come?" Chu Qingqiu frowned.

Elder Pingyao snorted lightly: "Flying Flower Sect sent a sick note, claiming that Sect Leader Hua Hong suddenly developed a headache and couldn't come."

Chu Qingqiu nodded: "Understood."

Ning Fuyi pursed her lips, despising in her heart. This headache came at such perfect timing. Moreover, such a large Flying Flower Sect didn't even have someone who could substitute.

An incense stick's time later, everyone gathered in Cloud Deep Hall, and the hall was momentarily silent.

Finally, Tang Wenshu spoke first. His waist was crooked, his face pale—clearly his injuries hadn't healed. His voice also lacked some vigor: "The situation is urgent now, so Tang won't exchange pleasantries."

"Yesterday I sent people to Penglai Realm, but they were repeatedly turned away. Penglai Realm's barrier is Nine Heavens Flowing Water, extremely difficult to break. Even though my sect's disciples shouted for a long time, they only got silence."

"Damn it!" The Ghost Sight Sect Master suddenly spoke, his voice hoarse. "Penglai Realm is clearly declaring war on us immortal sects. In my opinion, we might as well gather our armies and directly smash their barrier!"

"I think that makes sense," Li Hanmang said. "Anyway, once that ghost fire spreads, not to mention us, even the Six Realms will be finished. Better to fight them to mutual destruction!"

She cursed harshly: "We used to respect Penglai Realm's semi-divine status, but now it turns out to be a demon that fears the world isn't chaotic enough!"

"Everyone, please calm down first," Master Feiguang said with hands pressed together, lowering his brow. "Not to mention Penglai Realm's formidable strength—we can't even break their barrier. Just considering they hold Infinite Ghost Fire in their hands, if we anger Penglai Realm into completely releasing the fire seeds, the world will become a sea of fire, completely beyond redemption!"

"Then what should we do? Just endure like this?" the Ghost Sight Sect Master said.

Seeing everyone at an impasse, Tang Wenshu spoke again: "It's not about enduring, but we certainly can't be impulsive. The reason Penglai Realm spent enormous effort to forge Infinite Ghost Fire is that they regard it as a weapon capable of defeating or threatening us immortal sects."

"So before declaring war on Penglai Realm, we must at least know how to deal with Infinite Ghost Fire, only then can we avoid being at a disadvantage. Otherwise, when fire seeds are scattered everywhere, the world will truly be destroyed!" Tang Wenshu said.

Everyone was silent for a while, then nodded in unison, basically affirming his statement.

"Additionally, news came this morning that another fire seed has fallen. Fortunately, the fire seed fell near Kunlun Mountain, which is also an immortal mountain with few human traces. I've already sent disciples to control the fire," Tang Wenshu sighed.

The Ghost Sight Sect Master was so angry his beard stood up: "I think this fire is Penglai Realm's warning and test to us. Twice it fell in places with few human traces—if there's a next time, it might not be the case!"

"What does Penglai Realm want?"

Everyone shook their heads, then looked toward Chu Qingqiu, who hadn't spoken.

Chu Qingqiu paused, then continued along with the conversation: "They want us to panic and create chaos. When the world is in great turmoil and we have no time to care for each other, they'll appear, and we'll have to submit no matter what."

"How detestable!" The Ghost Sight Sect Master angrily turned in a circle, cursing harshly.

"So Sect Leader Tang is right. Our current plan can only be to first deal with Infinite Ghost Fire. But this Infinite Ghost Fire is chaos fire—how can it be easily extinguished?" Li Hanmang said with closed eyes.

Everyone fell into silence. Although all present were dragons among men, Infinite Ghost Fire was a creation artifact, very distant from them all.

After a quiet moment, Elder Pingyao suddenly pulled over Elder Jingshan, asking him to bring Scholar Yuan, who managed the Scripture Pavilion.

When the person appeared, she asked: "Scholar Yuan, you manage the Scripture Pavilion and naturally know more about ancient texts. Is there any mention of Infinite Ghost Fire among them?"

Logically, since Infinite Ghost Fire could disappear when chaos first opened, it proved there must be a way to make it disappear.

Scholar Yuan looked at everyone's hopeful faces and shook his head with a bitter smile: "Although the Scripture Pavilion has many books, Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate was only founded a thousand years ago and couldn't collect such ancient texts."

Seeing another deadlock approaching, Ning Fuyi's thoughts stirred. She pulled Chu Qingqiu's sleeve and whispered in her ear: "Fengdu²."

Chu Qingqiu turned her head and was about to say something when a female voice interrupted her words. Turning around, she saw Li Hanmang biting her lip and raising her palm with difficulty: "Everyone, I do have someone who might know something."

"Who?" Tang Wenshu asked.

"My Blissful Union Sect's master ancestor, Old Qiuguo. She's lived a long time and loves collecting ancient texts. Her knowledge is extremely vast. Perhaps she might have clues," Li Hanmang said, pinching her braid and seeming reluctant to speak.

"Now we can only treat a dead horse as if it were alive. Where is Old Qiuguo? We'll go visit her immediately," the Ghost Sight Sect Master stepped forward.

Li Hanmang smiled awkwardly again, her face wrinkling as she pointed downward.

"She's in the tomb," she said softly.

Two hours later, everyone boarded a lantern-decorated painted boat and landed on Blissful Union Island. Under the gaze of many beautiful men and women from Blissful Union Sect, they came to the uninhabited area behind the island and dug up Blissful Union Sect's ancestral grave.

The sect leaders all had unpleasant expressions on their faces. One by one, they followed Li Hanmang into the pitch-black tomb chamber, walking along the corridor while covering their noses, not daring to speak.

Chu Qingqiu walked at the back of the group. Though she wasn't afraid, she still habitually moved closer to Ning Fuyi's embrace. Ning Fuyi then raised her hand to half-embrace her, her heart melting into a pool of water.

She just wanted to experience more of Ning Fuyi's embrace.

Li Hanmang familiarly walked into the deepest tomb chamber, where a jade stone coffin was placed in the center. She tapped on the coffin with her fingers and said with an apologetic smile: "Master Ancestor."

Then an even more horrifying scene appeared. The lid of the jade stone coffin suddenly creaked open, and a white-haired old woman sat up stiffly, spitting out the jade hook she had been holding in her mouth.

"What year is it now?" a hoarse voice sounded.

Tang Wenshu quickly raised his sleeve to cover his face, not daring to look much. Even the Ghost Sight Sect Master stepped back, his expression complex. Master Feiguang simply started chanting sutras.

"Reporting to Master Ancestor, it's the 5,643rd year since Blissful Union Sect's founding," Li Hanmang said carefully, kneeling down.

"Strange, I've been lying here for so many years, why haven't I ascended to immortality yet?"

"Yes, it's been a hundred years since the last time you emerged from the coffin, and you still haven't ascended," Li Hanmang said with lowered head.

Old Qiuguo muttered some unclear words in confusion, then spoke: "Never mind, what's the reason for opening the coffin this time? Can't you manage Blissful Union Sect anymore, or have you taken a fancy to some girl or boy from another sect? Are you going to drug them?"

Ning Fuyi rolled her eyes elegantly, while Chu Qingqiu grabbed her sleeve and shook her head.

"Master Ancestor!" Li Hanmang tapped her palm on the coffin a few times, not daring to raise her eyes, saying softly: "This coffin opening truly has urgent business. Now Penglai Realm has scattered Infinite Ghost Fire, and the Six Realms are in peril."

"You are well-read in poetry and books, knowing everything in heaven and earth. Therefore, we want to ask you—do you know if this Infinite Ghost Fire can be extinguished?"

¹ Jianghu (江湖): The martial arts world or community

² Fengdu (酆都): In Chinese mythology, the capital city of the underworld